



Impact Fielder: Anukul Roy has frequently served as a specialist substitute fielder for his IPL teams. SPORTZPICS

easier entry point.

Playing without a wicketkeeper in the final overs

In 2015, Worcestershire made an unprecedented move in a NatWest T20 Blast game against Northamptonshire.

Defending a 212-run target, Worcestershire had Moeen Ali bowl the 16th over without a wicketkeeper, positioning regular stumper Ben Cox at fly slip without his pads and gloves.

This strategy allows the team an additional outfielder, which could be decisive in a closely contested match. It could work particularly well for a team with a wicketkeeper proficient in the outfield. Among the IPL 2025 teams, Rajasthan Royals could be an ideal candidate to experiment with this approach, given Sanju Samson's (pic, facing page) fielding skills.

Specialist substitute fielder

Before his breakthrough in IPL 2023, Rinku Singh was primarily used as a specialist substitute fielder by Kolkata Knight Riders. Anukul Roy's IPL career has followed a similar trajectory.

A substitute fielder provides valuable relief to fast bowlers in hot and humid conditions. A specialist in this role, however, can also save crucial runs in the field.

Interestingly, Cricket Australia is considering introducing a rule in the Big Bash League allowing teams to select a specialist fielder, who would then be replaced by a designated hitter when the side bats. The provision is designed to conserve the batter's energy and maximise their power-hitting ability.

Starting with three overseas players

Rajasthan Royals successfully

employed the strategy of fielding three overseas players on multiple occasions last season.

Against Delhi Capitals, it named only three — Jos Buttler, Shimron Hetmyer and Trent Boult — in its starting XI.

This gave it the flexibility to bring in pacer Nandre Burger when it bowled.

The move allowed Rajasthan to introduce Rovman Powell as an Impact Player in the event of a batting collapse, while also providing the cushion of a sixth bowling option if Powell was not required with the bat.

While most teams prefer to name four overseas players in their playing XIs, this strategy enables them to maximise the Impact Player provision and adjust their combination according to match situations.